CITY OF LOS ANGELES CHARTER AMENDMENT PRK

TITLE:
CITY DEPARTMENT OF RECREATION AND PARKS BUDGET.

THE ISSUE:
Should the City Charter be amended to increase the minimum budget for the Department of Recreation and Parks, phased in over ten years until it is double the current minimum budget allocation, with exceptions for fiscal emergencies?

THE SITUATION:
The Charter establishes a minimum budget for Recreation and Parks from the General Fund. That minimum budget is an amount equal to 0.0325% of the assessed value of all property as assessed for City taxes. The current Charter allocation percentage rate and the resulting budget allocation has not kept pace with the growing population, expanding park system, and increasing labor costs. This has contributed to reductions in Recreation and Parks services.

THE PROPOSAL:
This measure would increase the minimum amount of General Fund money provided to Recreation and Parks. The percentage would increase from 0.0325% to 0.065% of the assessed value of all property as assessed for City taxes, phased in over ten years. This measure would not create a new tax or generate additional City revenue. It would require more General Fund money to be provided to Recreation and Parks.

This increased funding would help address Recreation and Parks service levels, park equity gaps, and allow Recreation and Parks to cover the cost of operations and programs.

During a declared fiscal emergency, the City Council could reduce this increased funding by a certain amount. However, Recreation and Parks' minimum budget allocation could not be reduced below the current level of 0.0325% of assessed value of all property as assessed for City taxes.

A YES VOTE MEANS:
You want to increase the minimum budget for the Department of Recreation and Parks, phased in over ten years, with exceptions for fiscal emergencies.

A NO VOTE MEANS:
You do not want to increase the minimum budget for the Department of Recreation and Parks.

THE FULL TEXT OF THIS MEASURE BEGINS ON PAGE 63.

PRK CITY DEPARTMENT OF RECREATION AND PARKS BUDGET. CHARTER AMENDMENT PRK.

Shall the City Charter be amended to increase the minimum budget allocated to the Department of Recreation and Parks, phased in over ten years until it is double the current minimum budget allocation, with exceptions for fiscal emergencies?

IMPARTIAL SUMMARY
BY SHARON M. TSO, CHIEF LEGISLATIVE ANALYST

The General Fund is the primary operating fund of the City. General Fund revenue is used to fund City services such as police, fire, public works, transportation, libraries, and parks. General Fund revenues are derived from taxes, licenses, permits, fees, fines, and other sources.

The City Charter establishes a minimum budget allocation for the Department of Recreation and Parks from the General Fund. That minimum budget is an amount equal to 0.0325% of the assessed value of all property as assessed for City taxes. The current City Charter allocation percentage rate and the resulting budget allocation has not kept pace with the growing population, expanding park system, and increasing costs of maintenance and operations. This has contributed to reductions in Recreation and Parks services over time.

In 1996, voters approved the passage of the Proposition K: LA for Kids Program (Proposition K) which created a citywide assessment that has generated $25 million annually for the acquisition, development, improvement and restoration of parks and recreational facilities. The Proposition K program will expire in Fiscal Year 2026-27 and will result in the loss of funding to support parks and recreational facilities.

This measure would increase the minimum amount of General Fund money allocated to Recreation and Parks. These additional resources would help restore Recreation and Parks service levels, address park equity gaps, and allow the Department to cover the cost of operations and programs. The percentage would gradually increase from the current 0.0325% to 0.065% of the assessed value of all property as assessed for City taxes, phased in over a ten year period as follows:

- Fiscal Years 2026-2027 and prior: 0.0325%;
- Fiscal Year 2027-2028: 0.03575%;
- Fiscal Year 2028-2029: 0.039%;
- Fiscal Year 2029-2030: 0.04225%;
- Fiscal Year 2030-2031: 0.0455%;
- Fiscal Year 2031-2032: 0.04875%;
- Fiscal Year 2032-2033: 0.052%;
- Fiscal Year 2033-2034: 0.05525%;
- Fiscal Year 2034-2035: 0.0585%;
- Fiscal Year 2035-2036: 0.06175%;

- Fiscal Years 2036-2037 and thereafter: 0.065%

This measure would not create a new tax or generate additional City revenue. It would require more General Fund money to be provided to Recreation and Parks. Consequently, the amount of General Fund revenue available for other City services will be reduced.

During a declared fiscal emergency, the City Council could reduce the increased funding required in this measure by up to 30 percent for the duration of the fiscal emergency. However, Recreation and Parks' minimum budget allocation could not be reduced below the current level of 0.0325% of assessed value of all property as assessed for City taxes.

This measure will become effective if approved by a majority of voters.

FINANCIAL IMPACT STATEMENT
BY MATTHEW W. SZABO, CITY ADMINISTRATIVE OFFICER

This measure doubles the Department of Recreation and Parks' (RAP) property value based appropriation from 0.0325 to 0.065 percent over ten years. Assuming average property value growth, RAP's funding increases from $303 million to $995 million by 2036-37, with estimated annual increases attributed to the measure as follows: 2027-28 ($32 million), 2028-29 ($66 million), 2029-30 ($105 million), 2030-31 ($147 million), 2031-32 ($193 million), 2032-33 ($244 million), 2033-34 ($299 million), 2034-35 ($359 million), 2035-36 ($426 million), and 2036-37 ($497 million). All increases during this period are subject to actual assessed property value growth.

Because this measure does not raise new revenues, the City must reallocate resources from other services, including public safety, public works, and homeless services to meet the increased funding mandate. The City may suspend the mandated increase during a declared fiscal emergency. RAP remains responsible for reimbursing the General Fund for employee benefits and other related costs.

ARGUMENT IN FAVOR OF CHARTER AMENDMENT PRK

Charter Amendment PRK will keep our parks, waters, and beaches clean; repair and maintain park facilities; and keep recreation and senior centers open without raising taxes by a single penny.

LA's parks department runs over 500 parks, 123 recreation and senior centers, and 52 pools. These are affordable places for kids to play sports and stay safe after-school and in summer, for seniors to find services, and for families to gather. Parks and recreation centers host violence-intervention programs and provide services and shelter during wildfires and emergencies.

LA's parks dropped to 93rd of America's 100 largest cities in Trust for Public Land's 2026 ParkScore ranking. The City's parks assessment found LA funds parks two-thirds less than similar cities. Large staffing cuts mean parks are less safe and clean. Facilities need almost $3 billion in repairs, and pools, recreation, and senior centers have cut hours. Without action, more may close. One-third of Angelenos lack a park within a ten-minute walk of home.

Parks are critical services for Angelenos.

Protected parks funding has not increased since 1937, and money going directly to parks was reduced further since 2009.

PRK increases parks funding over 10 years, with protections for fiscal emergencies.

PRK will clean and improve parks, restrooms, pools and facilities; rebuild the parks and ranger workforce; protect beaches and coastal waters; build new parks where they're needed; restore natural areas; and invest in shade trees, wildfire prevention and nature-based solutions to protect our water.

It keeps pools and recreation and senior centers open and activates community school parks.

This funding requires strict fiscal accountability, and must be used only for eligible park purposes, with annual expenditure plans and reporting reviewed at public meetings and posted online.

Join community and environmental leaders to vote YES on PRK to fix parks without raising taxes.

PERSONS SIGNING ARGUMENT IN FAVOR OF CHARTER AMENDMENT PRK

MONICA RODRIGUEZ
Councilmember
City of Los Angeles

YSABEL JURADO
Councilmember
City of Los Angeles

IMELDA PADILLA
Councilmember
City of Los Angeles

KENNETH MEJIA
Controller
City of Los Angeles

FATHER GREGORY BOYLE
Founder
Homeboy Industries

TEFARAI BAYNE
Commissioner
LA Department of Recreation and Parks

BRUCE SAITO
Founder
Conservation and Youth Workforce Development Leader

NICOLE CHASE
President & CEO
Boys & Girls Club of San Fernando Valley

TORI KJER
Executive Director
LA Neighborhood Land Trust

BRUCE REZNIK
Executive Director
LA Waterkeeper

NO ARGUMENT AGAINST THIS MEASURE WAS SUBMITTED.

Arguments printed are the opinions of the authors and are not checked for accuracy by any City agency. In addition, the title beneath a signer's name is for identification purposes only and does not indicate that the individual is signing on behalf of the organization.

REBUTTAL ARGUMENT IN FAVOR OF CHARTER AMENDMENT PRK

Charter Amendment PRK is a responsible investment in parks, without raising taxes. Over 10 years, PRK will increase dedicated funding for parks while requiring strict accountability for every dollar spent.

Parks are a good investment.

Parks keep Angelenos healthy, active and connected. Physical inactivity accounts for 12.6% of healthcare costs. Research shows communities investing in parks have lower rates of stroke, heart disease, obesity, and diabetes. Every $1 spent on park programming lowers healthcare costs by $11.

Additionally, every $1 spent maintaining parks returns at least $3 in broader economic benefits. Tourism generated $35.1 billion in spending last year in Los Angeles, supporting over 224,000 jobs. Griffith Park and Venice Beach, both city parks, are among our biggest draws.

PRK will create good, local jobs, improve public health, maintain safe children's play areas, fully re-open recreation and senior centers, keep beaches clean, and repair restrooms citywide.

Vote YES on PRK.

PERSONS SIGNING REBUTTAL ARGUMENT IN FAVOR OF CHARTER AMENDMENT PRK

MONICA RODRIGUEZ
LA City Councilwoman

IMELDA PADILLA
LA City Councilmember

YSABEL JURADO
LA City Councilmember

KENNETH MEJIA
LA City Controller

LUIS A SANCHEZ
President
LA Rec and Parks Board of Commissioners

JIMMY KIM
General Manager
LA Department of Recreation and Parks

JON CHRISTENSEN
Adjunct Assistant Professor
UCLA

AMBER MARTINEZ
President & CEO
Los Angeles Parks Foundation

DEBORAH COHEN, MD, MPH
Public Health & Preventative Medicine

MONA FIELD
Past President
Greater Los Angeles League of Women Voters

Arguments printed are the opinions of the authors and are not checked for accuracy by any City agency. In addition, the title beneath a signer's name is for identification purposes only and does not indicate that the individual is signing on behalf of the organization.

New provisions or language added to the Charter or to existing Charter sections are shown in underline type; words deleted from the Charter or from existing Charter sections are shown in ~~strikeout~~ type.

CHARTER AMENDMENT PRK
(CITY DEPARTMENT OF RECREATION AND PARKS BUDGET)

TEXT OF THE PROPOSED BALLOT MEASURE

Section 1. Section 593 of the Charter of the City of Los Angeles is amended to read as follows:

Sec. 593. Financial Support.

(a) For the financial support of the Department of Recreation and Parks, there shall be appropriated an annual sum of not less than the following percentage ~~0.0325%~~ of assessed value of all property as assessed for City taxes:~~.~~

Fiscal Years 2026-2027 and prior: 0.0325%
Fiscal Year 2027-2028: 0.03575%
Fiscal Year 2028-2029: 0.039%
Fiscal Year 2029-2030: 0.04225%
Fiscal Year 2030-2031: 0.0455%
Fiscal Year 2031-2032: 0.04875%
Fiscal Year 2032-2033: 0.052%
Fiscal Year 2033-2034: 0.05525%
Fiscal Year 2034-2035: 0.0585%
Fiscal Year 2035-2036: 0.06175%
Fiscal Years 2036-2037 and thereafter: 0.065%

(b) Additional appropriations may be made from the General Fund.

(c) All money derived from (a) or (b), plus all other sums received by the department shall be placed to the credit of the Recreation and Parks Fund.

(d) Except as provided in Section 342 with regard to funds appropriated from the General Fund to the Recreation and Parks Fund, money in the Recreation and Parks Fund shall be used only for the financial support of the Department of Recreation and Parks.

(e) In the event the City Council, by two-thirds vote, declares a fiscal emergency by resolution, the financial support required under subsection (a) may be reduced by up to thirty percent (30%) of the total amount of the stated percentage of assessed value of all property as assessed for City taxes following such declaration and such reduction may remain effective until the expiration of the fiscal emergency, provided that at no time shall such reduction decrease the total financial support otherwise required under subsection (a) to lower than 0.0325% of assessed value of all property as assessed for City taxes.

Sec. 2. Severability. If any section, subsection, clause, sentence, phrase, or application of this Charter amendment or any portion thereof is held unconstitutional or invalid by any court or tribunal of competent jurisdiction, the remaining sections, subsections, clauses, sentences, phrases, portions, or applications of this Charter amendment shall remain in full force and effect,

and to this end the provisions of this Charter amendment are severable. In addition, the voters declare that they would have passed all sections, subsections, clauses, sentences, phrases, portions, and applications of this Charter amendment without the section, subsection, clause, sentence, phrase, portion, or application held unconstitutional or invalid.